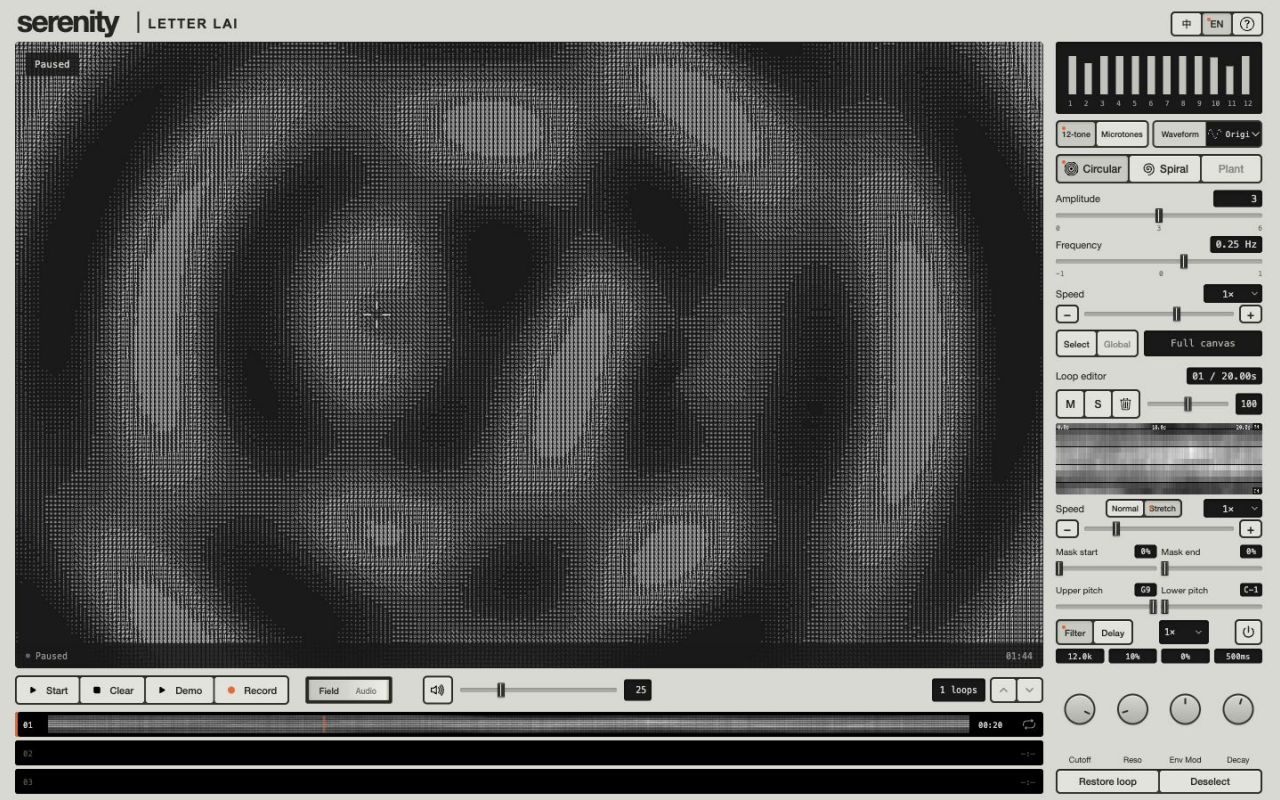
serenity

User Guide



Serenity in use

Turn an evolving field into evolving sound.

Serenity is an audiovisual instrument you play in a browser. Plant circular or spiral fields, choose where to listen, capture independent layers, then shape their rhythm, tone and echoes.

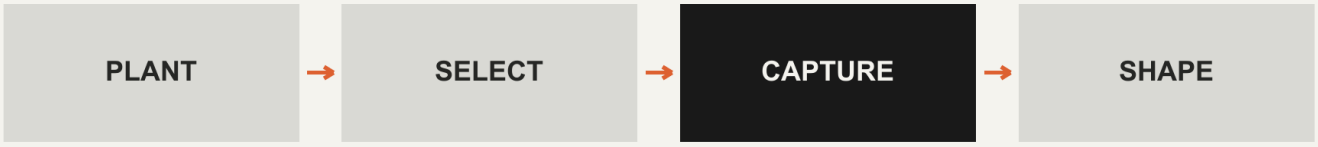
This guide assumes no prior knowledge of synthesizers or music theory. Diagrams explain the controls; screenshots show the current web version.

LETTER LAI · English edition

Play online: https://laiyutao.github.io/serenity-web/

01 Your first three minutes

From an evolving field to independent sound layers.



From field to layers

1. Enable audio. Choose Begin or Demo. Start with a low master volume, then raise it gradually.

2. Choose capture mode, then sound mode. After pressing Field or Audio, the 12-tone and Microtones buttons lose their selection. Select 12-tone or Microtones again to confirm the sound mode before recording. For a first try, choose Field and 12-tone.

3. Plant a field. Click the screen to position the cursor, choose Circular, then press Plant. You can also double-click the screen.

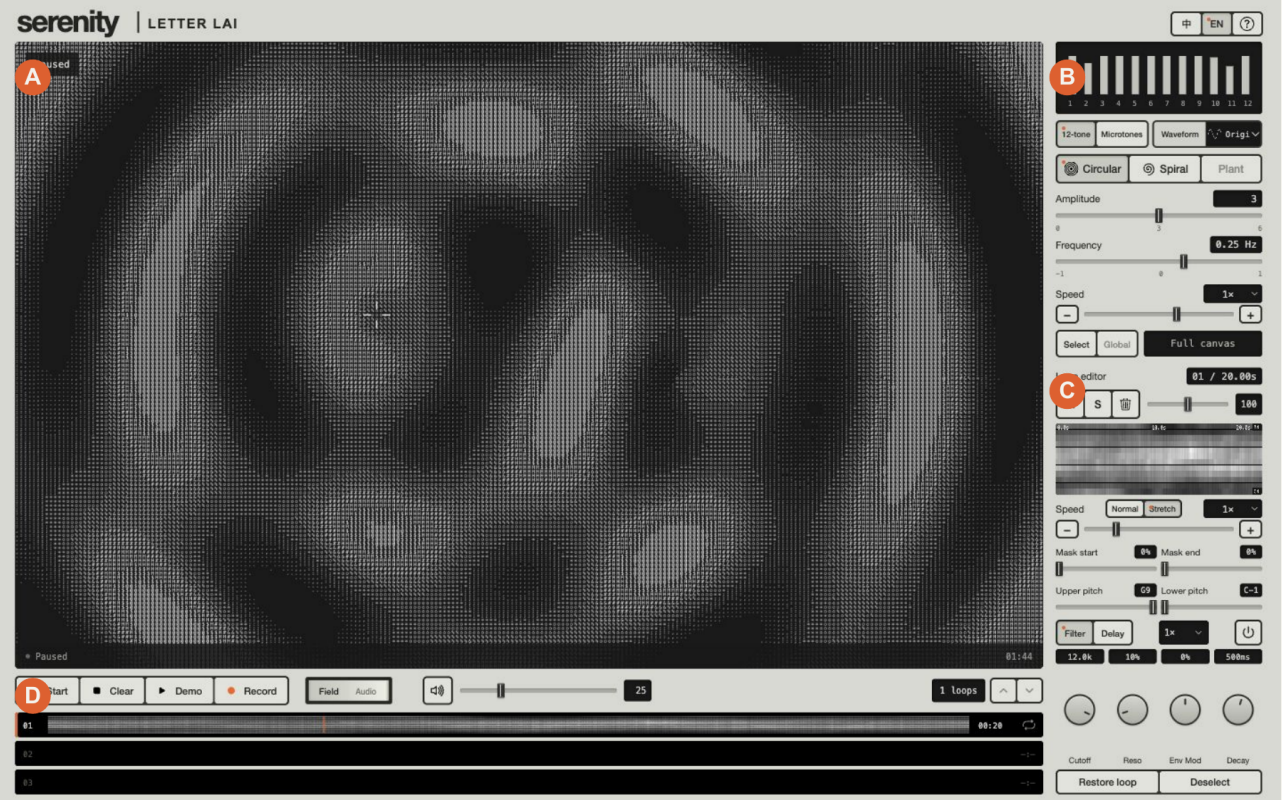
4. Change one parameter. Select a source and slowly move Amplitude or Frequency. Changes spread outward rather than updating the whole screen instantly.

5. Listen locally. Press Select, drag a region, then press Select again to finish. Compare the selected region with Global listening.

6. Capture a layer. With Field selected, press Record once. After processing, an independent loop appears below.

7. Add a little space. Select the track, open Delay and add some Mix. Pause the live field to hear your captured layer on its own.

02 Find your way around



Interface map

A Main screen: fields and regions. This shows the combined field. Circular waves stay circular as the number of displayed cells adapts to the window shape.

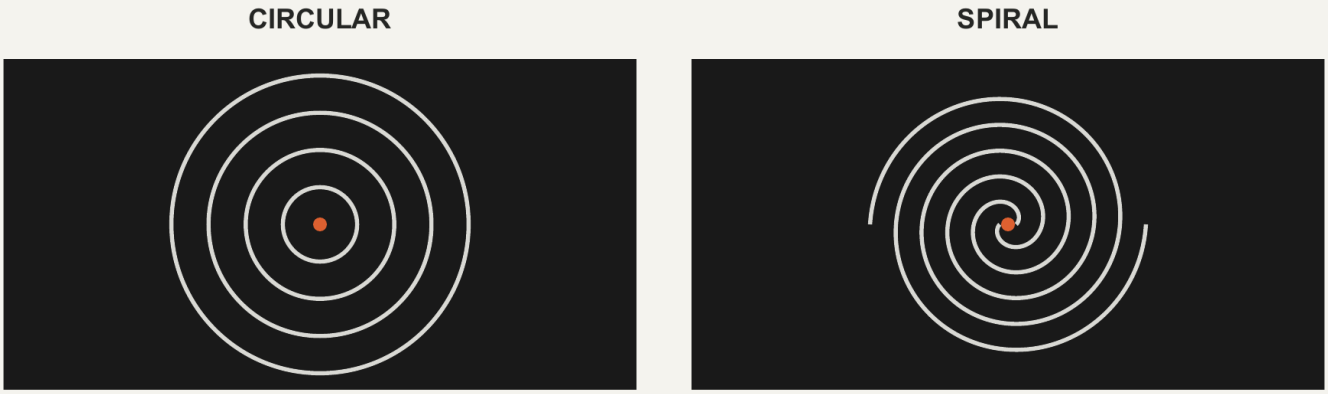
B Upper right: live sound creation. Find the pitch bars, 12-tone / Microtones, Waveform, source controls, Amplitude, Frequency, live Speed and listening regions here.

C Lower right: selected-track processing. Volume, M / S, the sound display, track Speed, masks, pitch limits and Filter / Delay affect the selected track only.

D Bottom: transport and layers. Live transport, Clear, Demo, Record, recording mode, master volume and the track list. Three tracks are shown per page; use the up/down arrows for more.

Chinese / EN changes the interface language. Hover over LETTER LAI to reveal the email address; click the name to copy it.

03 Shape a field first



Circular and spiral field diagrams

A source continuously drives the image. When fields meet, they add to or cancel one another, creating new patterns and sound. The lines above explain the shapes; the instrument itself uses grayscale characters.

Control	What it does
Circular	Expands around a point; an easy place to start.
Spiral	Angular phase differences create a rotating pattern.
Amplitude	Sets the field's strength from 0 to 6, not its track volume.
Frequency	From -1 to 1 Hz; controls the source's evolution. Zero gradually freezes reached cells.

Select an existing source to edit it. At an empty position, the settings apply to the next source you plant. A source cannot be planted twice at the same position.

Two meanings of frequency. The upper Frequency control describes field evolution, not the pitch you hear. Sound also depends on the height distribution in the listening region.

04 Choose where and how to listen



Listen inside the regions, including incoming fields.

Regions and sound mapping

Select can add multiple rectangles without replacing earlier ones. Press it again to finish; Global returns to the full screen. Overlapping regions do not count the same cells twice.

A region chooses where to listen, not which sources are allowed to sound. A field outside the region can still propagate into it and change what you hear.

12-tone: height bands control the proportions of twelve fixed pitches. Their changing mixture creates chords and clusters.

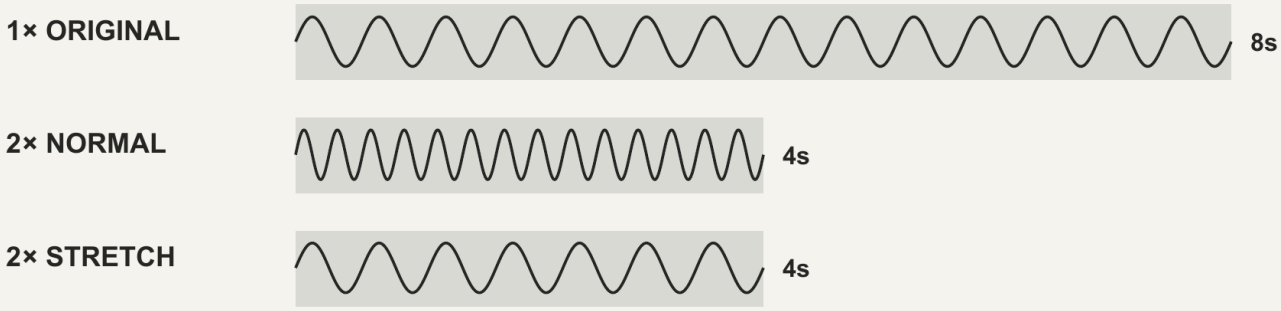
Microtones: the distribution produces one continuously changing pitch, which can move between semitones.



Five waveforms

Waveform changes texture: Sine is pure, Triangle softer, Saw and Square brighter. Original follows the original voicing; in Microtones, Original uses a sine tone.

05 Live speed and track speed



Normal versus Stretch

Upper Speed: changes the live field and its sound. Positive values run forward; negative values reverse the evolution. Magnitude sets the rate. Reversal starts from the current shape without undoing sources. Captured tracks stay independent. Live pitch follows the speed magnitude; this control does not use Stretch.

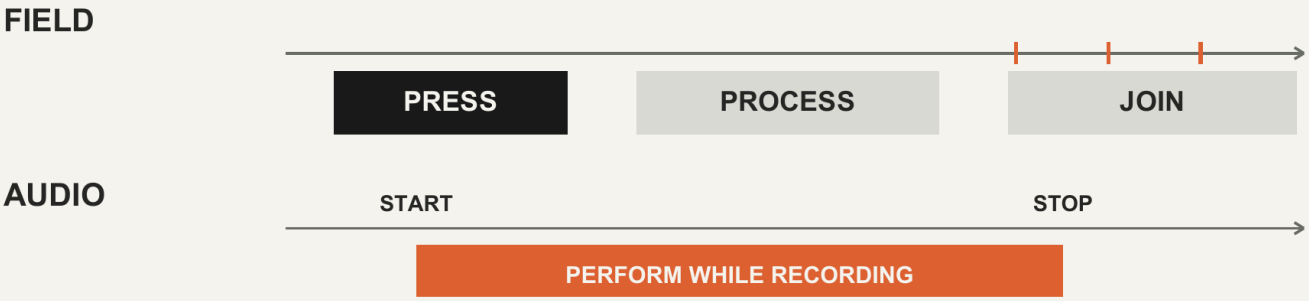
Lower Speed: changes only the selected track, from 0.25 to 4×. Use the slider for fine changes, the readout for quarter-step presets, or the minus/plus keys.

Mode	What 2× does
Normal	Half the duration, one octave higher.
Stretch	Half the duration, original pitch retained.

Stretching a direct recording may add texture, especially at extreme rates. Try comparing the modes around 0.75-1.5× first.

Pause is not master mute. Live transport pauses the current field and its sound, while captured tracks keep playing. Master volume and the speaker button control all output.

06 Field capture or direct recording?



Two ways to capture sound

Confirm the sound mode before recording. Each time you press Field or Audio, the 12-tone and Microtones buttons lose their selection. Select 12-tone or Microtones again, then press Record.

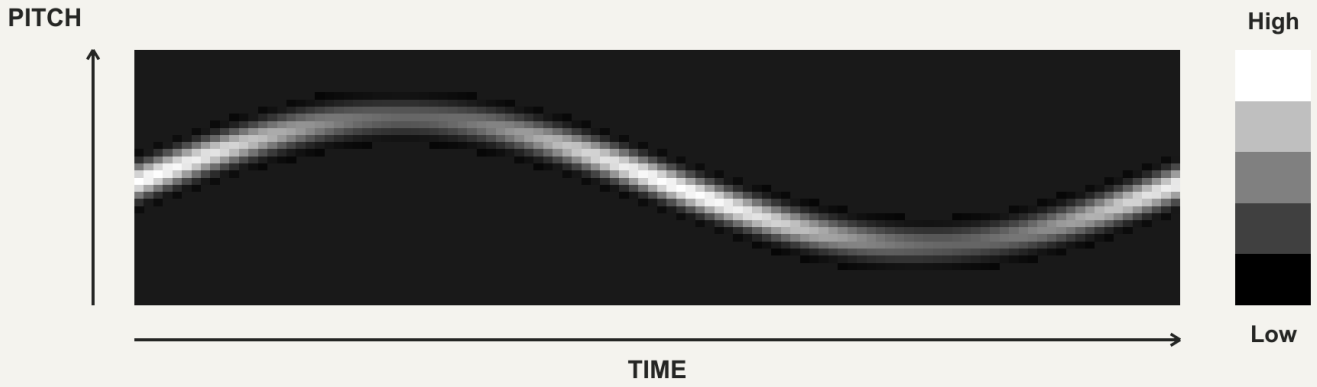
Mode	Best for
Field	Capture the current field's sound evolution. One press computes a field cycle and compensates processing time to join the live position.
Audio	Record an actual performance. Press Record to start and again to stop; keep changing speed, waveform, regions and sources while recording.

Both modes capture only the live field, never the existing track mix. Audio mode does not record a microphone. A direct recording needs at least about half a second.

A field cycle is not one acoustic oscillation. A 0.25 Hz field repeats in 4 seconds, a 0.20 Hz field in 5 seconds. Together they may take 20 seconds to realign, while many faster audible oscillations occur inside that span.

For an easy-to-follow loop, let the field and parameter changes settle before capturing. A microtonal pitch contour can repeat without the fine audio oscillation returning to exactly the same phase at the boundary; pitch does not need to be retuned to force it.

07 Work with independent layers



Reading the sound display

Keep up to 16 tracks, with three visible per page. Click a track to show its controls on the right. Selecting another track preserves each track's settings.

The display runs through time horizontally and pitch vertically. Brighter areas indicate greater relative intensity; black indicates silence or masking. It is neither a single oscilloscope trace nor an output decibel meter.

Control	Meaning
Volume	100 is unity gain, 0 silent, 200 twice the signal gain, not necessarily twice the perceived loudness.
M / Mute	Silence this layer without deleting it.
S / Solo	Hear only soloed recorded layers; the live field remains a separate input.
Delete	Removes the track; use M instead for temporary silence.

To audition a layer, pause the live field and use S. A muted track still keeps its display and content.

08 Make space with masks



Black sections are muted; loop length stays the same.

Ordinary and wrapping time masks

A time mask silences a section; it does not select the only section to play. Start 25% and End 50% mute the middle quarter while the rest keeps its original loop position.

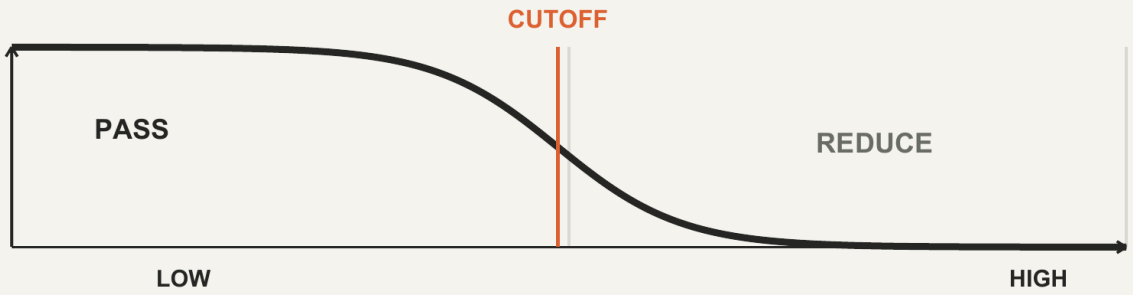
To cross the loop boundary, set Start to 75% and End to 25%. This mutes the last quarter and the first quarter. Equal start and end values mean no time mask.

You can also drag horizontally across the sound display to mark a masked interval. Its black areas follow the time mask.

Upper pitch / Lower pitch keep pitches inside the band and remove those outside it. Readouts show note names such as C4 or G9. This is pitch selection, not clipping the tops of the waveform.

Restore loop resets masks, pitch limits, track speed and effects. **Deselect** only clears the selection; it does not stop or delete the layer.

09 Filter: shape brightness



Low-pass filter diagram

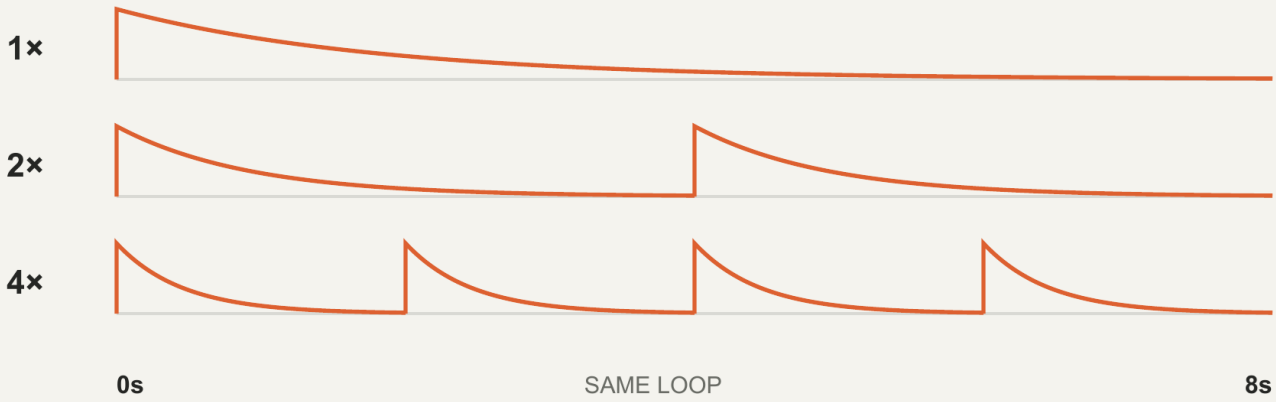
Filter is a low-pass filter: lower frequencies pass more easily while higher ones are reduced. It can soften bright harmonics or sweep automatically through the loop.

Knob	What to listen for
Cutoff	Lower values darken the tone; below the fundamental, the whole sound can become quieter.
Reso	Emphasizes the cutoff region, adding definition or a sharper, resonant character.
Env Mod	Positive sweeps brighten then darken; negative sweeps darken then brighten; zero disables the sweep.
Decay	Sets how long the sweep takes to return: short and plucky, or slow and breathing.

Start with a Saw or Square layer, set Env Mod to zero and move Cutoff alone. Learn the brightness change before adding motion. A pure sine has few harmonics, so filtering may sound mainly like a volume change.

Filter / Delay switches the control page. Both groups can work together. Moving a knob enables that group; use its power key to compare enabled and bypassed sound.

10 Repeats, not playback speed



Sweeps within one eight-second loop

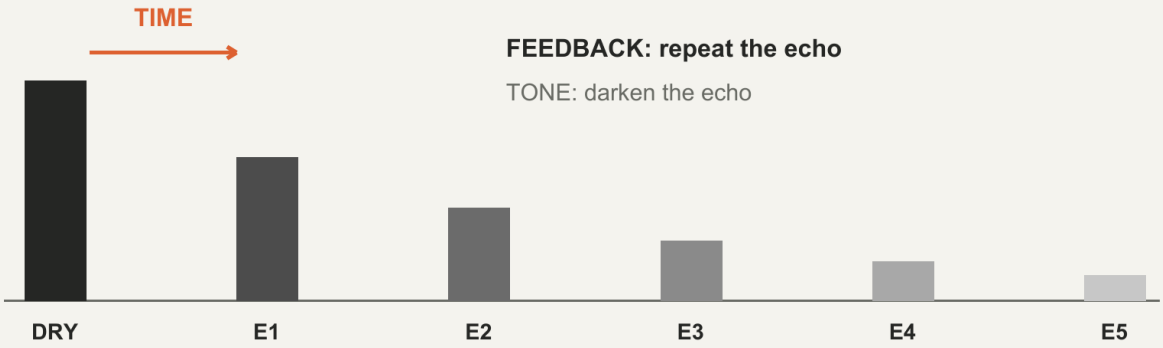
The Filter clock's 1×, 2×, 4× and 8× set **how many automatic sweeps happen during one track loop**. More repeats create denser movement without speeding up the track itself.

An 8-second loop	Sweep interval
1×	Once every 8 seconds
2×	Once every 4 seconds
4×	Once every 2 seconds
8×	Once every 1 second

Repeats sets how often a sweep begins; Decay shapes its return. At 4×, a short Decay feels pulsed and a long one more continuous. With Env Mod at zero, repeats and Decay do not create an audible automatic sweep.

Try Cutoff 250Hz, Reso 25%, Env Mod +50% and Decay 500ms. Compare 1×, 2× and 4× without changing the track speed at the same time.

11 Delay: add echoes



Echo timing and decay

Delay plays earlier sound again after a gap. Feedback repeats the echo, and Tone changes its brightness. This is an effect tail, not another captured track.

Knob	Meaning
Time	In Free mode, sets the gap from about 10ms to 2s.
Feedback	More feedback sustains more repetitions; begin around 25%-35%.
Mix	Balance of dry and delayed sound: 0% dry only, 100% delayed only.
Tone	Darkens the echoes with a low-pass filter; it does not directly darken the dry sound.

Free uses the Time knob. **1/2, 1/4, 1/8 and 1/16** use a fraction of the whole loop. In synced mode, Time shows the calculated value and is not adjustable.

For a 4-second loop, 1/4 means 1 second; for a 20-second loop, it means 5 seconds. This is not a BPM-detected quarter note. Overlong choices are disabled; the delay limit is about 16 seconds.

12 Three exercises to try

REGION | FILTER | DELAY

From a dry layer to movement and space

Hear a region change

Load Demo and choose Microtones. Compare Global with a small region, then try another position. Listen for changes in pitch. Capture a Field layer and pause the live field.

Make a breathing layer

Capture a Saw or Square Field layer. Set Filter to Cutoff 250Hz, Reso 25%, Env Mod +50%, Decay 500ms and 4×. Then set track Speed to 0.75× in Stretch mode.

Record a gesture and echo it

Choose Audio, reselect 12-tone or Microtones, start recording, slowly change the upper live Speed, then stop. Add Delay: Free, 350ms, Feedback 35%, Mix 25%, Tone 3kHz. Compare Normal and Stretch track-speed modes.

Change one knob at a time. Understand one change before adding another. Use the effect power key to compare before and after without losing your settings.

13 Quick reference and troubleshooting

Key	Action
W A S D	Move the planting cursor
J / K	Plant Circular / Spiral
Hold J + W / S	Adjust selected-source amplitude
Hold K + W / S	Adjust selected-source frequency
J + K	Switch 12-tone / Microtones
Space	Pause / resume the live field
M	Master mute
R / X	Clear the field / Return to welcome
Esc	Finish region selection

No sound? Click Begin and check master volume/mute. Make sure a field exists, or try Demo. For a silent track, inspect M / S, masks, pitch limits and Cutoff.

Why is another sound still audible in Solo? S manages captured tracks only. Pause the live field to audition a track alone.

How do I adjust a knob precisely? Drag vertically or scroll, hold Shift for fine control, and double-click to reset. Synced Delay Time is read-only.

Before reloading? Tracks live in the current page session and are lost on reload or close. Changing language does not clear them.

Contact: Hover over LETTER LAI to reveal the email, then click the name to copy it.

Play online: https://laiyutao.github.io/serenity-web/